Green AI Bingo

Every AI answer runs on electricity and water in a data centre. Most of the waste comes from habits. Check off a square each time you practise a habit this week. Five in a row in any direction is a **GREEN line**.

Name (optional): _____ Class / library: _____ Date: _____

G Get to the point	R Right-size the tool	E Edit, don't redo	E Easy on media	N Know the numbers
Full context first	Calculator for math	Edit, don't regenerate	Stock photo first	One prompt's footprint
Set a length	Small model first	Save good answers	Skip AI video for fun	Data centre growth
Batch your questions	Reasoning only if needed	Ask once, clearly FREE	2 images, not 20	BC grid vs. the cloud
New topic, new chat	Dictionary for one word	Reuse a prompt	Sketch it first	Know the land
Thanks in-line	Spell-check first	Fix one part only	Clean up cloud files	Teach someone

Get to the point: one clear prompt beats five follow-ups.

Right-size the tool: a calculator or small model is often enough.

Edit, don't redo: fix your prompt instead of regenerating.

Easy on media: AI images and video use far more energy than text.

Now you know the numbers. Facts, sources and the interactive game are at **gaiathinker.ca/green-ai-bingo**

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Run Green AI Bingo in 20 minutes

Warm-up · 5 min

Ask: “Where does an AI answer actually come from?” Collect guesses, then share the “One prompt’s footprint” and “BC grid vs. the cloud” facts below.

Play · 10 min

In pairs, students pick the habits they already have and choose one new one to try. Online version: gaiathinker.ca/green-ai-bingo (no accounts, no data collected).

Reflect · 5 min

Each learner commits to one habit for the week. FPPL link: “Learning involves recognizing the consequences of one’s actions.”

Keep it honest. A single text prompt uses very little energy (Google reports about 0.24 Wh for a median Gemini prompt; researchers say that figure is incomplete). The impact comes from scale and from the heaviest uses: large models, reasoning modes, images and video. Figures come from different studies, so treat them as orders of magnitude.

All 30 habits. Each printed card uses 24 of them, plus the free square.

G · GET TO THE POINT

Full context first: Before you hit send, include the goal, who it’s for, and the format you want. Chat models re-read the whole conversation on every new message. Five rounds of “no, I meant…” makes the model process your early messages again and again. One clear prompt avoids the repeat work.

Set a length: Add “in 3 bullet points” or “under 100 words” to your prompt. AI writes one small piece of a word (a token) at a time and runs the whole model once for each one. A 100-word answer needs a fraction of the computing of a 1,000-word one.

Batch your questions: Group three related questions into one message instead of sending three. Each message re-sends the conversation so far. Fewer round-trips means less repeated reading.

New topic, new chat: Switching subjects? Open a new chat instead of continuing a long thread. A long thread is re-read with every new message, even when the old part has nothing to do with your new question.

Thanks in-line: Stay kind: put your thanks inside your next real question, not in a message on its own. A standalone “thanks!” still triggers a full model reply. Courtesy is good; an extra round-trip isn’t needed.

Show one example: Paste one short example of the style or format you’re after. A clear example gets you closer on the first try, which means fewer retries and fewer regenerated answers.

R · RIGHT-SIZE THE TOOL

Calculator for math: Use your calculator for arithmetic, percentages and unit conversions. Researchers at Hugging Face and Carnegie Mellon found general-purpose generative AI models use orders of magnitude more energy than models built for a single task. A calculator is the ultimate single-task tool. [4]

Small model first: For spelling, short summaries or quick rewrites, choose the “mini”, “fast” or “lite” model. In MIT Technology Review’s tests, a small open model (Llama 3.1 8B) used about 114 joules per answer. A large one (405B) used about 6,706 joules, roughly 60 times more. [3]

Reasoning only if needed: Turn on “think longer” or reasoning modes only for problems that really need them. These modes write long hidden chains of reasoning before answering. More text generated means more computing.

Dictionary for one word: Look up one word’s meaning or translation in a dictionary app. A dictionary lookup retrieves stored text. A chat model generates a new answer from scratch every time.

Spell-check first: Use your device’s built-in spell-check and grammar check first. Built-in checkers are small, single-task tools, often running right on your device. Save the AI pass for feedback they can’t give.

Unused AI features off: Switch off auto-summaries, suggested replies or AI previews you never read. Automatic AI features generate output whether or not anyone reads it.

E · EDIT, DON’T REDO

Edit, don’t regenerate: Not quite right? Fix your prompt once instead of pressing “regenerate” five times. Every regenerate produces a complete new answer from scratch.

Save good answers: Copy a useful answer into your notes so you don’t have to ask again. Opening a note costs almost nothing. Asking again means generating the whole answer again.

Reuse a prompt: Keep a prompt that worked well and reuse it next time. A tested prompt gets a good answer on the first try, so you skip the trial and error.

Fix one part only: Ask for “rewrite paragraph 2 only” instead of a full rewrite. Rewriting the whole piece generates every word again. Editing one part generates only what changed.

Read it all first: Read to the end before asking a follow-up. The answer may already be there. Skimming leads to follow-ups the first answer already covered, and every follow-up is another full round-trip.

Share one answer: Working in a group? Share one AI answer instead of everyone asking the same question. Five people asking the same question means five separate answers generated.

E · EASY ON MEDIA

Stock photo first: Use a free stock photo or your own picture before generating an image. In MIT Technology Review's tests, one AI image (Stable Diffusion 3 Medium) took about 2,282 joules. That's about 20 times a small model's text answer. [3]

Skip AI video for fun: Save AI video generation for when you really need it. In the same tests, a 5-second AI video took more than 700 times the energy of a high-quality AI image. [3]

2 images, not 20: Generate a couple of options and refine one, instead of twenty variations. Each image is a separate, energy-heavy generation, so the variations you throw away still used power.

Sketch it first: Sketch your idea before describing it to an image generator. A clear picture in your head means a better first prompt and fewer attempts.

Clean up cloud files: Delete duplicate photos and videos from your cloud storage. Stored files sit on servers that use power around the clock. The impact per file is small, though. The bigger win is not creating and uploading what you don't need in the first place.

Autoplay off: Turn off autoplay in your video and social apps. Autoplay streams video through data centres and networks even when no one is watching.

N · KNOW THE NUMBERS

One prompt's footprint: Read how much energy and water a single AI text prompt uses. Google reports its median Gemini text prompt uses about 0.24 Wh of electricity and 0.26 mL of water, about the same as watching TV for under nine seconds. Independent researchers say the method leaves some things out, so treat it as a lower bound. [1] [2]

Data centre growth: Look up how much electricity data centres use, and where that use is heading. The International Energy Agency projects global data-centre electricity demand will more than double by 2030, to about 945 TWh, with AI as the biggest driver. [5]

BC grid vs. the cloud: Find out where your AI provider's data centres are, and how clean their grid is. BC Hydro generates over 98% of its power from clean, renewable sources. But most AI runs in data centres outside BC, often on grids that burn more fossil fuels. Where the computing happens matters. [6]

Know the land: Learn whose traditional territory you live on. Then think about the land where data centres are built. Data centres need land, water and power. Thinking about place connects digital choices to real ecosystems and communities. "Learning involves recognizing the consequences of one's actions." (First Peoples Principles of Learning) [7] [8]

Teach someone: Share one green AI habit with a friend or family member. Habits spread through people. One conversation can multiply your impact.

Read an eco report: Find your AI provider's latest sustainability report and pick out one number. Companies publish energy, water and emissions data. Reading it yourself builds the habit of checking claims instead of trusting headlines.

SOURCES

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